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NEWSPAPER

7th November, 2017

ITEM WISE EDITORIALS

45th WEEK



SAUDI ARABIA... ARRESTS...ITS IMPACT

UPSC CSE – GS II

GS II... EFFECT OF POLICIES AND POLITICS OF DEVELOPING COUNTRIES ON INDIA'S INTERESTS.



Learning Space

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NEWSPAPER EDITORIALS

... DISCUSSION

7th NOVEMBER, 2017

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Royal flush

The reasons behind the Saudi Crown Prince's surprise crackdown are still not clear

Ever since he was named the defence minister of Saudi Arabia in 2015, Mohammed bin Salman has had little patience for the way the kingdom is being ruled. In June, two and a half years into the reign of his father King Salman, he replaced Mohammed bin Nayef as Crown Prince. In recent weeks, he had taken on the Salafi religious establishment. On Sunday he spearheaded another surprise by ordering the arrest of senior government ministers, officials and 11 Princes, including the billionaire Abwaleed bin Talal, and the powerful chief of the National Guard, Mutaib bin Abdullah. The immediate reason for the arrests is not known. The palace version is that they were carried out as part of a new campaign against corruption that is spearheaded by Prince Mohammed. But the recent crackdowns suggest that Prince Mohammed is consolidating his power. He first had Prince Nayef removed from his path to the throne as Crown Prince. As one of the richest among Saudi royals, Prince Abwaleed is known for his cosy ties with Western governments and less conservative views. Prince Mutaib, a favourite son of the late King Abdullah, is an influential figure within the palace. By arresting both, Prince Mohammed has potentially neutralised the money and power centres that could pose challenges to him in the future.

With the latest arrests, at just 32 years of age Prince Mohammed appears to have established himself as the most powerful Saudi Crown Prince in decades. He is practically in charge of key policy decisions and has taken control of all branches of the Saudi security services – the military, internal security and the National Guard. He clearly has the King's ear. Still, Prince Mohammed is playing a risky game. In a short span of time, he has opened multiple fronts in the still unfolding internal power struggle. In Saudi Arabia, where the rulers traditionally distribute power among the different branches of the royal family as a balancing tactic and get their decisions approved by the *shura* for legitimacy, Prince Mohammed's moves are upending tradition. By concentrating power in his own hands and turning against other Princes as well as some clerics, he has upset the balance in the system. Quick consolidation of power could perhaps allow him to reshape the governance model. The anti-corruption campaign, which sounds much like that led by Chinese President Xi Jinping, will have popular support, which he could use to continue to target his rivals. But Prince Mohammed's track record so far is devoid of any major achievement. His ambitious plan to reform the economy has been a non-starter. His foreign policy moves also backfired with the Yemen war spinning further out of control and the Syrian civil war turning in favour of President Bashar al-Assad, who is seen as an adversary by Riyadh. If he continues to make mistakes the game could go awry, triggering an open power struggle within the House of Saud. With the Riyadh-Tehran rivalry in West Asia hotting up again, these developments are also bound to have repercussions beyond Saudi Arabia.

2 Royal flush

Date :7th November, 2017

The reasons behind the Saudi Crown Prince's surprise crackdown are still not clear. Ever since he was named the defence minister of Saudi Arabia in 2015, Mohammed bin Salman has had little patience for the way the kingdom is being ruled. In June, two and a half years into the reign of his father King Salman, he replaced Mohammed bin Nayef as Crown Prince. In recent weeks, he had taken on the Salafi religious establishment. On Sunday he sprang another surprise by ordering the arrest of senior government ministers, officials and 11 Princes, including the billionaire Alwaleed bin Talal, and the powerful chief of the National Guard, Mutaib bin Abdullah. The immediate reason for the arrests is not known. The palace version is that they were carried out as part of a new campaign against corruption that is spearheaded by Prince Mohammed. But the recent crackdowns suggest that Prince Mohammed is consolidating his power. He first had Prince Nayef removed from his path to the throne as Crown Prince. As one of the richest among Saudi royals, Prince Alwaleed is known for his cosy ties with Western governments and less conservative views. Prince Mutaib, a favourite son of the late King Abdullah, is an influential figure within the palace. By arresting both, Prince Mohammed has potentially neutralised the money and power centres that could pose challenges to him in the future.

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2 Royal flush

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NEWS REPORT

**PRINCE ALWALEED BIN TALAL**

- Saudi Arabia has arrested dozens of senior figures including Princess, Ministers and they include top Business Tycoon Prince Alwaleed bin Talal.
- With the authorities pledging fair Justice, this is seen as consolidating the Crown Prince hold on Power.
- Prince Alwaleed bin Talal is one of the richest people in West Asia.
- The head of the Saudi National Guard, once a leading contender to the throne, as well as Navy Chief and the Economy Minister were replaced.
- The shake up comes at a time of unprecedented social and economic transformation in ultra conservative Saudi Arabia.
- Total 11 Princess, 4 current Ministers and dozens of ex-Ministers were arrested as the Commission launched a probe in to old cases





LATE KING ABDULAZIZ



KING SALMAN



CROWN PRINCE MOHAMMED BIN SALMAN

WHAT IS THE SYSTEM IN SAUDI ARABIA?

- 1 There is one Allegiance Council. This Allegiance Council is made up of sons and prominent grand sons of the founder of the Saudi State, the late King Abdulaziz, who vote to pick up the King and Crown Prince from among themselves
- 2 A few months ago, Saudi Arabia's King Salman appointed his 31 year old Mohammed bin Salman as Crown Prince. So he will be the first in line to the throne. This change happened after replacing 57 year old nephew Prince Mohammed bin Nayef from his powerful position.

CROWN PRINCE MOHAMMED BIN SALMAN ... CONSOLIDATION OF POWER

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- 1** Replacement of Mohammed bin Nayef from his title as Crown Prince and from his powerful position as the Country's interior Minister in the month of June shows the consolidation of power by the Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman.
- 2** Now, the Government says that these arrests were part of the new campaign against corruption spearheaded by Prince Mohammed.
- 3** By arresting Prince Alwaleed and Prince Mutaib, Prince Mohammed has potentially neutralised the money and power centres, which may pose challenges to him in the future.
- 4** The consolidation of 32 year old Prince Mohammed appears to be evident. Normally in the Kingdom, rulers traditionally distribute power among different branches of the Royal family as a balancing tactic and get their decisions approved by the ulema for legitimacy.
- 5** Quick consolidation of power could perhaps allow him to reshape the governance model.





SAUDI ARABIA ... THE CIVIL WARS

- 1** The foreign policy moves also backfired with the Yemen war spinning further out of control.
- 2** Syrian war is turning in favour of President Bashar al-Assad

**SAAD HARIRI**

Prime Minister, Lebanon

RESIGNATION OF LEBANON PRIME MINISTER SAAD HARIRI

- 1 Saad Hariri made to announce his resignation, while on a trip to Riyadh. The Saudi had supported Hariri, a dual Saudi-Lebanese citizen in forming his delicately balanced coalition Government.
- 2 Saudi Arabia was not happy as he had allowed Iran backed Hezbollah into his cabinet.



Cyprus

Mediterranean Sea

ISRAEL

SYRIA

LEBANON

Sea of Galilee

Jordan River

Dead Sea

IRAQ

JORDAN

EGYPT

Gulf of Aqaba

SAUDI ARABIA

CONTROL OF PRINCE MOHAMMED... NEAR TOTAL

- 1** The control of Crown Prince Mohammed is near total.
- 2** He is going for reforms by giving women long demanded driving rights.
- 3** At the same time, he is pushing a forward looking Vision 2030 Statement.
- 4** Government also introducing reforms with moderate interpretation of Quran by also clipping the wings of the previous all powerful religious police.
- 5** Now the control of the Crown Prince over National Guard, military and internal security is total



WHAT IS THE MESSAGE TO INDIA?

1 India need to tread cautiously.

2 West Asia is roiled by supremacy fight between Iran's Shias and Saudi Arabia.

3 Saudi's have traditionally supported Pakistan with cash infusions, but it is now paying heed to India's raising global stature.

4 Saudi Arabia is also India's second largest oil supplier.

5 It is home to almost four million remittance sending Indians.

6 At the same time, Iran is also quite important for us as India is building Chabahar port.

India should tread cautiously to maintain delicate balance in complex West Asia.

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